SQUEEZE PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular squeeze play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

Having the defender's hands visible at the second page is not a perfect scenario. For example, there will be situations where you, as Declarer, are still playing for a suit to split 3-3 when you only have to peek at the hands to see that the split is 4-2. However, the other possibility of keeping the defender's hands hidden until later would prevent you from seeing how your plays are squeezing them. On balance, we decided to use the more open method.

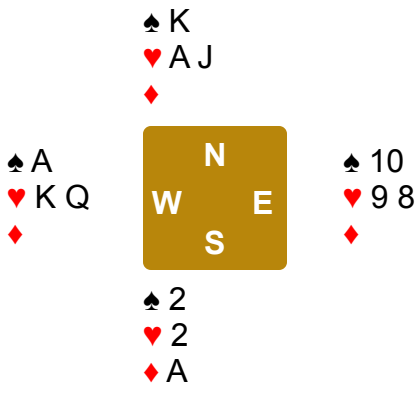
You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

You will notice that a large portion of the 20 Deals are slam hands. This is not because Squeezes don't arise in lower contracts, just that the presentation and explanations are less cluttered when there is only one (or none) trick that can be lost.

SQUEEZE PLAYS SUMMARY

The basic principle of a Squeeze Play can be summed up with this statement.

> A DEFENDER CANNOT HOLD ON TO THREE GUARD CARDS WHEN HE HAS ONLY TWO CARDS IN HIS HAND



South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

West cannot throw his ♠A because dummy's ♠K would then be high.

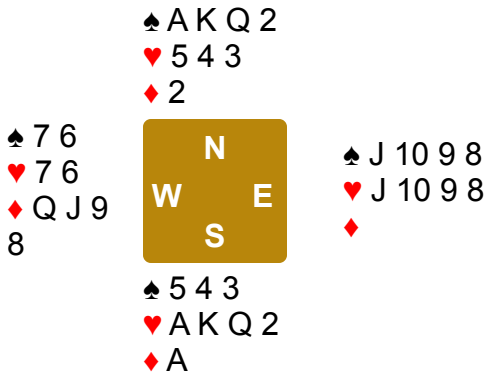
But he also cannot throw his ♥Q because then South would discard dummy's ♠K and win two tricks with ♥A, ♥J.

We say that West is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all three cards at a time when he had to come down to just two.

The statement in the blue box is definitely True, but it isn't complete.
You could also say:
A defender cannot hold four guards when he has only three cards.

Or even:
A defender cannot hold eight guards when he has only seven cards.

You get the idea. Look at an example of the eight and seven situation:



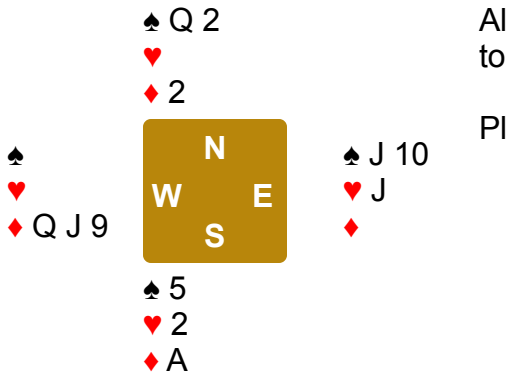
South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

East needs to keep all 4 ♠s to stop dummy's ♠2.

But he also must keep all 4 ♥s to stop your ♥2, (though he might not realize the importance of this).

We say that East is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all eight cards at a time when he had to come down to just seven.

Perhaps it is already obvious to you that all those extra winners in each hand don't affect the fundamental squeeze position. Take the last example and play dummy's ♠ A K and then your own ♥ A K Q. You would then have this basic position:



All the extra winners have already been won and you are down to basics.

Play the ♦A and squeeze East in ♠s and ♥s.

There are three terms we use when talking about squeezes.

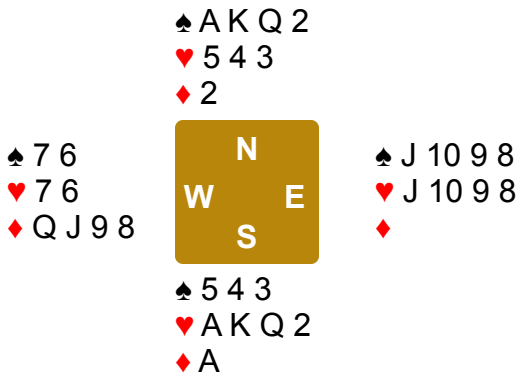
A **THREAT** is a card which is not yet a winner but THREATENS to become a winner if a defender discards a higher card in the suit. In the example above your ♥2 and dummy's ♠2 are both Threats.

A **GUARD** is a card(s) held by a defender that is preventing one of your Threats from becoming a winner. East's ♠ J 10 is a Guard against dummy's ♠2 and East's ♥J is a Guard against your ♥2.

The **SQUEEZE CARD** is the card you play which forces a defender to give up one of his Guards. Here the Squeeze Card was the ♦A.

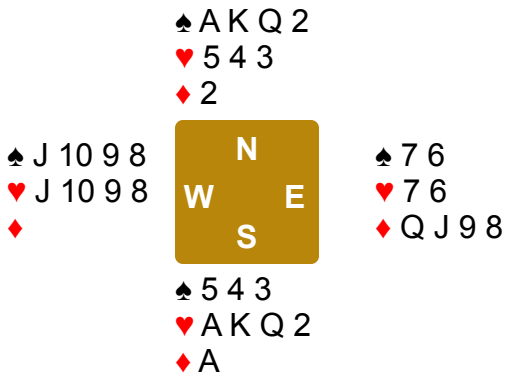
Automatic Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



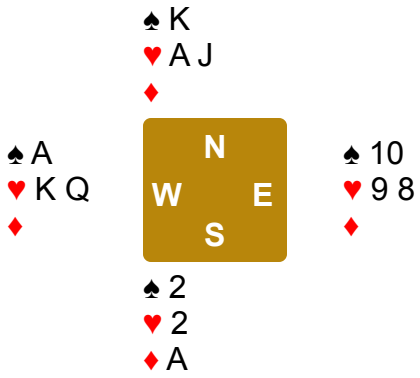
South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

An automatic squeeze is just a squeeze which will work equally well against either defender.

Deal 1 shows you a full example of an automatic squeeze. Feel free to go there right now and then come back for the next bit.

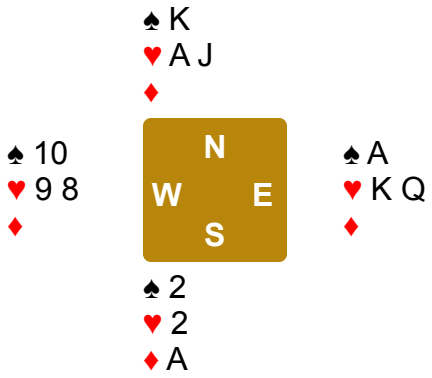
Positional Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is not squeezed at all!
In fact it is dummy that is squeezed. Since dummy has to play before East does, East just watches and discards the same suit as dummy.

This is a Positional Squeeze, so called because it only works on one of the Defenders.

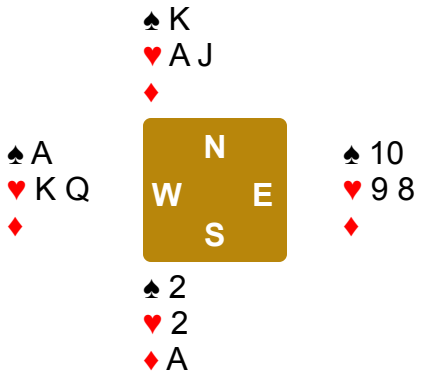
Deal 2 is an example of a positional squeeze. Feel free to go check it out, then come back.

Rectifying the Count:

That may sound rather high-tech but it's not really that bad.

MOST SQUEEZES CAN ONLY OCCUR WHEN
YOU MUST WIN ALL THE REST OF THE TRICKS

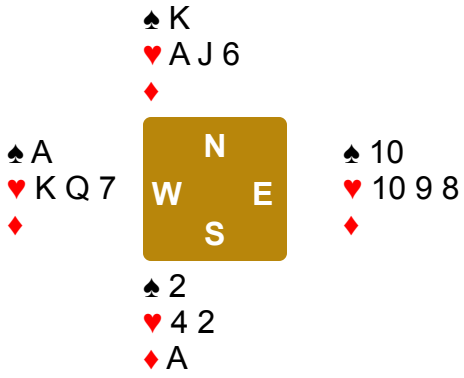
Look at this end position one more time.



South needs to win all the rest of the tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.
He is squeezed because all of his cards are Busy - they are all doing guardwork.

Now give everybody an extra ♥.



South needs to win 3 of the last 4 tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is not squeezed.
He has one card, the ♥7, which is not Busy doing guardwork.
So he just discards that card and awaits his two tricks.

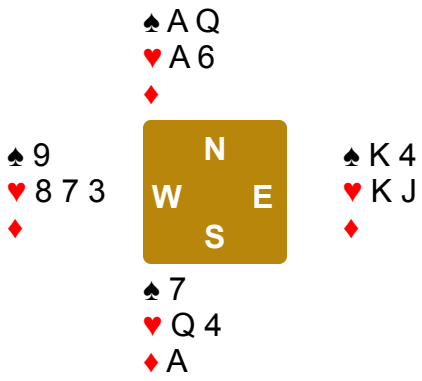
If you checked out Deals 1 and 2 earlier you didn't run across this problem. And for a very good reason - both of those Deals involved Grand Slams so you were already in a spot where you needed the "rest of the tricks".

When you are playing a small slam, though, rectifying the count is vital. So when your Plan calls for a squeeze to be made at the end you will have to give up one trick to the defenders early.

Deal 3 (surprise) just happens to demonstrate rectifying the count. So if you want to see it work in the context of a full deal just check that out and then come back when you are done.

The Vienna Coup:

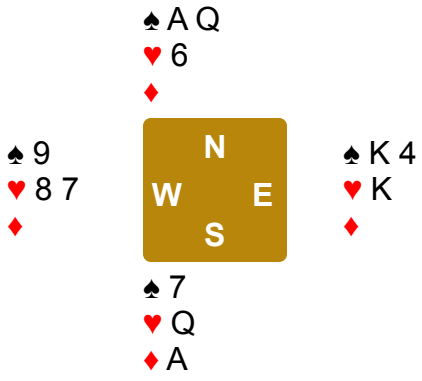
Nice name, huh?
Take a look at this ending, where South needs to win all four tricks. South is in her hand and can certainly win the three Aces. She has two Threats, the ♠Q and the ♥Q with which she hope to squeeze East.



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East will throw his ♥J because he can see that he must hold onto both ♠s.
Dummy's ♥A now drops the ♥K, and establishes South's ♥Q.
BUT SHE HAS NO ENTRY TO IT, SHE IS LOCKED IN DUMMY.

So, let us apply the Vienna Coup! At some earlier time, perhaps the first trick, or the fourth trick or whenever, dummy's ♥A was played. So the ending would now look like this:



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East is squeezed in ♥s and ♠s.
The difference here is that South no longer needs an extra entry to her ♥Q because she is already in her hand.

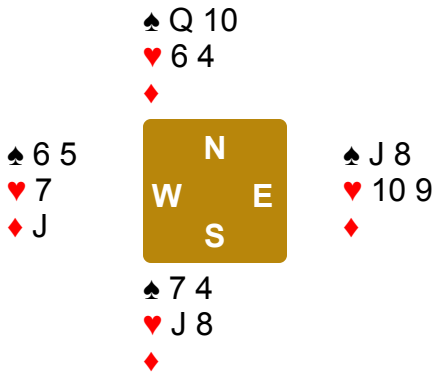
THE VIENNA COUP IS THE CASHING OF A HIGH CARD IN ONE HAND TO CREATE A THREAT IN THE OTHER HAND

Want to see the Vienna Coup in action?
Go to Deal 7, then come on back.

The Suicide Squeeze: (aka the Cannibal Squeeze)

This squeeze often occurs when the defenders have made a mistake, but there are some situations where they defend perfectly and still get caught in it. What happens is that one defender cashes a winner and in so doing squeezes his partner.

Look at this ending:



West cashes the ♦J.

Discard the ♥4 from dummy and the ♠4 from your hand. East is squeezed and you win the last three tricks.

If West had just ignored the ♦ winner and led one of the other suits East would have been assured of taking 2 tricks.

There is just one Suicide Squeeze Deal presented in this set so I won't identify it for you, just be on the lookout.

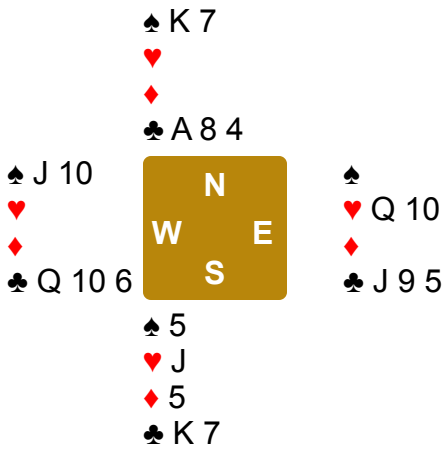
The Double Squeeze:

Usually you think of a squeeze occuring when one defender is trying to guard two suits. In these descriptions we have often said "East is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s." But sometimes when you are trying to set up a squeeze on one player it will turn out that West guards one suit but East guards the other suit. So you try to get a situation where neither one can guard a THIRD suit.

That sounds messier than it should. Suppose you have a long ♦ suit which you play to use for a squeeze. It turns out that West guards a ♠ threat while East guards a ♥ threat.

You will say to yourself: "West guards the spades, East guards the hearts, nobody can guard the clubs."

Here is how it works:



You play your ♦5.

West is not squeezed, but he must keep both ♠s to guard against dummy so he is forced to discard a ♣. Since you know your ♠7 cannot win a trick now you throw it. East is not squeezed, he can spare the ♥10.

But you then play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K. This squeezes East who now has the sole guard for both ♥s and ♣s. He will probably throw his ♣5 in which case you take the last 3 ♣ tricks.

Deal 13 is a good example of a Double Squeeze.

That's all folks:

I didn't start this lesson by talking about how difficult Squeeze Plays are. As you have seen, though, they do require some effort, both learning how to execute them and in the execution itself. Most of the examples here are classified as Simple Squeezes. There is another whole level.

If your interest is piqued you might want to look for the Vise Squeeze, or perhaps the Winkle and the Stepping-Stone squeeze. How about the Trump Squeeze or the Criss-cross squeeze?

Good luck.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **7NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



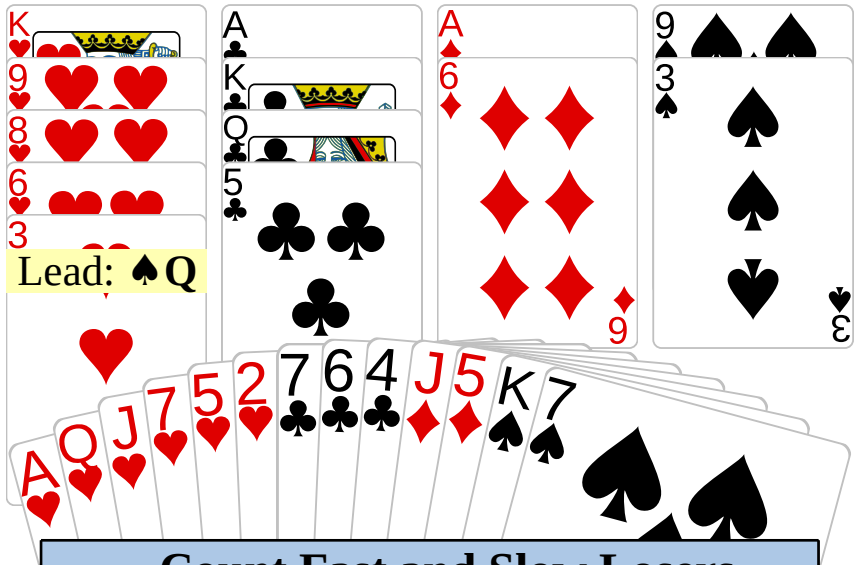
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦J

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 7 ♥ A Q 9 8 6 2 ♦ Q 7 ♣ 7 5 2	
♠ Q 10 9 3 ♥ 10 5 4 ♦ K J 10 ♣ A K Q	N W E S	♠ 6 5 4 2 ♥ J ♦ 9 8 4 3 ♣ J 10 9 3
	♠ A K J ♥ K 7 3 ♦ A 6 5 2 ♣ 8 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣J

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♣J. West wins ♣ A K Q then switches to a trump.

West takes ♣ A K Q then switches to a trump.

You must win the next 10 tricks but you only have 9 winners.

West opened 1NT, showing 15-17 points, and East has already produced 2 Jacks. So both the ♠Q and ♦K are with West and you will have to put the squeeze on him.

You are in dummy, having won their trump exit with the ♥K.

Since you need all the tricks the count is already rectified.

You plan to squeeze West by running the long ♥s in your hand.

The ♦Q was not a Threat card yet: to make it a Threat you had to unblock dummy's ♦A. Then you pull trumps with the ♥ A Q.

Unblocking the ♦A to make your ♦Q a squeeze Threat is called the Vienna Coup.

With 6 cards left to be played you are ready to apply pressure to West.

Play the ♥ 9 8, discarding ♦s from dummy. West is not troubled yet, he can discard the ♦J and the ♠3.

West is now looking a little nervous, like he has a big target on his back!

East discards.

Play the ♥6 and throw dummy's ♦6.

West can choose his fate. If he throws the ♠9 you will know that his ♠Q will drop since his third card **MUST** be the ♦K. So you would just play to the high ♠s and the ♠J would be good.

Or, he can throw his ♦K which makes your ♦Q a winner.

That worked great, right? Let's back up and pretend you had NOT unblocked the ♦A. We will just add one ♦ to everybody's hand and look at the ending.

Now when you play your ♥6 as a squeeze card you have a problem. You are squeezing dummy, not West.

If you discard the ♦6 West will throw his ♦J, then sit back and wait for his ♠Q trick.

But if you discard dummy's ♠J instead, West will match that by throwing his ♠9, then sit back and wait for his ♦K trick.

Only by visualizing the ending and using the Vienna Coup can this hand be made.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ K 9 8 4 3
♥ 10 8 6 2
♦ J 10 7 3
♣ —

♠ A 2
♥ 9 3
♦ A K 8 6
♣ K Q 10 6 5



♠ Q 7
♥ A 4
♦ Q 5 4
♣ A J 9 7 3 2

♠ J 10 6 5
♥ K Q J 7 5
♦ 9 2
♣ 8 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3♣	Pass
4♣	Pass	4♥	Pass
4♠	Pass	6♣	
All Pass			

6♣ by East
Lead: ♥K

East is to play 6♣. South leads the ♥K.

You have 11 top tricks and hope for a 3-3 ♦ split to give you one more. If they don't split you can hope that the defender with 4 ♦s also holds the ♠K and that a squeeze will be possible.

You win the first trick and pull trumps in two rounds, ending in dummy.

In case the squeeze becomes necessary you rectify the count by giving up a ♥.

South takes the ♥ trick and plays the ♦9 which you win with your ♦Q.

South plays low.

The key play: taking dummy's ♠A before running three rounds of ♣s.

Unblocking the ♠A to create a Threat out of your ♠Q is the Vienna Coup.

South discards.

North was able to find discards on your first three trump leads, but when you play the ♣7 and discard dummy's ♠2 he is squeezed.

He can see that if he discards a ♦ dummy will be high, so he will probably throw the ♠K in hopes that his partner holds the ♠Q. But you have that card and you make the slam.

As an afterthought to this Deal, let us suppose you were playing 6NT rather than 6♣.

The only difference would be that to rectify the count you would have to hold up once on the opening ♥K.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K Q 7 5 2 ♥ 8 6 4 ♦ 7 5 ♣ 6 3	
♠ 9 ♥ 10 5 3 2 ♦ Q J 9 6 4 2 ♣ 10 7		♠ J 10 8 6 ♥ 9 7 ♦ 10 8 3 ♣ J 9 8 4
	♠ 4 3 ♥ A K Q J ♦ A K ♣ A K Q 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT	Pass	7NT
All Pass			

7NT by South
Lead: ♦Q

North's 3NT rebid shows 6 ♠s headed by A K Q and nothing else. South is to play 7NT. West leads the ♦Q.

Nice hand. You have 12 high card tricks and either a 3-2 ♠ split or a 3-3 ♣ split will land this Grand Slam. But even if neither suit splits nicely you can STILL make it if the same defender holds 4 cards in both suits; in that case you will squeeze for the thirteenth trick.

You win the ♦K.

Win the ♦K and (**IMPORTANT!**) test the ♣s first by playing ♣ A K Q. Darn. West discards a ♦ on the ♣Q.

Alright, so East holds the ♣ Guard. You still need to exercise caution.

Play your 4 ♥ winner's next. West follows suit while East follows twice, then discards 2 ♦s.

Don't play ♠s yet!

Play your ♦A. East must give up.

If he throws the ♣J, you win. But if he throws a ♠ you also win. This is what is called a Win-Win bridge play.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

♠ 8 5 3
♥ Q 10 7 2
♦ J 10 8 4
♣ 6 3

♠ A K Q J
♥ 9 5 3
♦ K Q
♣ 10 8 7 4



♠ 10 6
♥ A K 8 6
♦ 9 7 3
♣ A K Q J

♠ 9 7 4 2
♥ J 4
♦ A 6 5 2
♣ 9 5 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♠	Pass	6NT	
All Pass			

6NT by West
Lead: ♦J

West is to play 6NT. North leads the ♦J. South takes the ♦A and returns the ♦2.

Your 4 ♠ tricks, 2 ♥ tricks, 1 ♦ trick and 4 ♣ tricks are very easy to find. But that's only 11, so where in the world can you possibly find number 12?

With all those high ♦s falling on the first two tricks dummy's ♦ 9 has become a threat against North. If it should happen that North also holds the only ♥ stopper you can squeeze him in the red suits.

You are going to run your black suit winners, taking the ♣s first so you can be playing winners from your hand when you squeeze North.

On the last 2 ♣s North discards a ♦ and a ♥.

Now come to your hand with the ♠A and play the ♠ K Q.

You discard a small ♥ from dummy while North follows suit three times.

It is time.

North discards the ♥7, holding on to the ♦10.

Play your ♠J and watch what North discards.

If he holds on to the ♦10 you will discard dummy's useless ♦9 and hope the ♥s all fall under the ♥ A K.

If he discards the ♦10 then you throw dummy's small ♥ and dummy wins the last three tricks.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 9 3 ♥ K Q ♦ A K Q J 9 3 ♣ Q 8 3	
♠ J 10 8 6 ♥ A 8 4 2 ♦ 5 ♣ K 9 4 2	N W E S	♠ 7 4 2 ♥ J 10 9 6 3 ♦ 8 6 4 ♣ J 6
	♠ A K Q 5 ♥ 7 5 ♦ 10 7 2 ♣ A 10 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6NT by North
Lead: ♥J

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♥J. West wins the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

With only 11 winners you need to find one more and your prospects are quite slim.

No matter how the ♠s split only one defender will hold the Guard because only one defender can have as many as 4. IF (it's a big IF) that same defender holds the ♣K then you can squeeze him.

Can you see how the squeeze is going to work?

If you try to run your ♦s right away you will have a problem with your ♣Q later on. It will be no good as a Threat card because you will have no entry back to your hand.

East plays low.

The solution is the Vienna Coup: a ♣ to the ♣A at trick 3.

Then start running the ♦ suit.

This is the situation after you have unblocked dummy's ♣A and then played 5 ♦ winners.

So far neither defender is hurting, but that is about to change.

East discards.

You play your ♦3 and discard dummy's ♣10.

West is squeezed. He can't throw his ♣K without letting your ♣Q become a winner. But if he discards a ♠ dummy's ♠5 will win the last trick. This is soooo much fun.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A 8 5 2 ♥ 4 ♦ K Q 8 3 ♣ J 10 9 3	
♠ 9 3 ♥ K 9 8 6 3 ♦ A 6 ♣ A K Q 5		♠ K 7 ♥ A Q J 7 5 2 ♦ J 5 ♣ 7 6 4
	♠ Q J 10 6 4 ♥ 10 ♦ 10 9 7 4 2 ♣ 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

Play 5 ♥ winners and the ♠K.

Drum roll please.

South discards.

Play your ♥2 and dump dummy's ♦6.

North has no answer.

East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠Q. North wins the ♠A and plays the ♦K.

Of course you have noticed that in most of these hands you are exactly one trick short. No coincidence - it's when you are one trick short and can't find another likely plan that you start to look for a squeeze.

In this hand dummy's fourth ♣ is an obvious Threat, so you should ask yourself if you can find another Threat for when ♣s don't split 3-3. Another thing you have probably noticed is that although 3-3 splits happen about 40% of the time in real life, they **NEVER** happen in these pages!

North's ♦K play helps you find the other Threat. It appears that he must hold the ♦Q also, so your ♦J is now a Threat against North. If he holds 4 ♣s you can squeeze him.